

By Shyam Lal Yadav

In Assam, there are 1.5 lakh voters who have been identified as doubtful citizens, but their names are still on the voter list. And for the Election Commission of India, it's a near impossible job to identify each and every voter whose citizenship is in question. Of course, the Government conducts a census after every 10 years, but these reports are not enough to address various contentious issues such as 'illegal' voters.

Pratibha Patil and her family will be registered for the NPR. Based on this NPR, the newly created Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) will issue identification numbers to citizens. The programme will have to be completed along with the first phase of the 2011 Census—house listing and housing census. The data collection for the NPR will be completed in a phased manner by September. This will be the largest exercise of its kind in which approximately 80 crore people aged 15 years and above will be allotted a UID.

Beyond the COUNT

The 2011 Census will also gather data for the National Population Register based on which every citizen above 15 years of age will be provided with a Unique Identification Number



The 2011 Census, however, seeks to be a completely new exercise from the previous ones—along with the two usual forms of census data, there will be a third one which will gather data for the National Population Register (NPR). After the NPR data is ready, every citizen will be allotted a Unique Identification Number (UID). On April 1, Union Home Minister P. Chidambaram will kick-start an extensive data gathering exercise at the Rashtrapati Bhavan where the details of President

They may later be issued identity cards though this proposal is yet to be cleared by the Cabinet.

The whole exercise of Census 2011 will cost approximately Rs 2,200 crore while the NPR will cost Rs 3,539.24 crore. Thus Rs 7,000 crore—along with the Registrar General of India's (RGI) own expenses—will be spent on this exercise. The Union Cabinet last week approved the expenses of the NPR. Considering the normal growth rate of our population, India will be home to

over 120 crore people by March 1 next year, the cut-off date for the census. That means roughly Rs 59 will be spent per person for this head and house counting and preparing the NPR. While inaugurating the All India Conference on National Population Register, Chidambaram said, "Nowhere in the world has a government tried to count, identify and issue identity cards to more than a billion people. This is perhaps the biggest exercise of its type since humankind came into existence." Says

